Conversations with my Father

By Herb Gardner

EDDIE: A Russian Jew determined to make it in America, 20-30
JOEY: His 10-year-old son

INTRODUCTION

Fighting never solved anything . . . . use your words, not your fists. . . . Mothers just don't get it. Sometimes you have no choice but to fight. It's a matter of pride. And defending your heritage. The year is 1936 and in this scene, Jewish born Eddie Goldberg has escaped to America and made a new life for his family in New York. Out of the frying pan and into the proverbial fire for 10 year old Joey, who is being harassed by another boy in the neighborhood. Fortunately, his father has a better answer to the dilemma than his mother.

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JOEY: (Entering, thoughtfully, with stack of mail.) Pop, the sign outside, it says "Ross" on it . . .

EDDIE: That's our new name, you're gonna love it; honor o'Barney himself. (Takes mail, starts going through it.)

JOEY: You mean not just for the place, but actually our new name?

EDDIE: All done; legit and legal, kid. Al Gladstone presidin' (Takes envelope from mail.) Son of a bitch, The Sons of Moses, Pop's yahrzeit again. . .

JOEY: So my name is Joe Ross? That's my name now? Joe Ross? Very. . . brief, that name. . .

EDDIE: (Studying blue card from envelope.) Fifteen years, they find me every time, it's the Royal Mounted Rabbis. . .

JOEY: Joe Ross, it starts - it's over. . .

EDDIE: Hey, Hebrew School

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JOEY: (Suddenly alarmed.) Jeez, went right outta my mind (Grabs Hebrew-texts, races for door, slapping yarmulkeh on his head.)

EDDIE: Wait a minute - (Points to yarmulkeh.) Where ya goin' with that on your head? What're ya, crazy? Ya gonna go eight blocks through Little Italy and Irishtown, passin' right through Goddamn Polack Street, with that on your head? How many times I gotta tell ya, kid - that is not an outdoor garment. That is an indoor garment only. Why don't ya wear a sign on your head says, "Please come kick the shit outa me?" You put it on in Hebrew School, where it belongs.

JOEY: Pop, I don't

EDDIE: I'm tellin' ya once more - stow the yammy, kid. Stow it.

JOEY: (Whips yarmulkeh off, shoves it in a pocket.) O.K., O.K. (Starts toward door.) I just don't see why I gotta be ashamed.

EDDIE: I'm not askin' ya to be ashamed. I'm askin' ya to be smart. (Sees something in the mail as Joey opens door; sharply) Hold it

JOEY: Gotta go, Pop

EDDIE: Hold it right it there

JOEY: Pop, this Tannenbaum, he's a killer

EDDIE: (Looking down at mail, solemnly) I got information here says you ain't seein' Tannenbaum this morning. I got information here says you ain't even headed for Hebrew School right now. (Silence for a moment. Joey remains in doorway) Cmere, we gotta talk.

JOEY: (Approaching cautiously, keeping at a safe distance.) Hey. . . no whackin', Pop. . .

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EDDIE: I got this note here; says - (Takes small piece of cardboard from mail, reads.) "Dear Sheenie Bastard. Back of Carmine's, Remind you, Jewshit Joe, Eight o'clock A.M., Be there. Going to make Hamburger out of Goldberger - S.D." Bastard is spelled here B-A-S-T-I-D; this and the humorous remarks I figure the fine mind of the wop, DeSapio. (After a moment, looks up, slaps bar.) And I wanna tell ya good luck, glad you're goin', you're gonna nail 'im, you're gonna finish 'im, you're gonna murder 'im.

JOEY: Wait a minute - it's O.K.? Really?

EDDIE: - and here's a couple pointers how to do so.

JOEY: Pointers? Pointers? - I need a shot-gun, Pop; DeSapio's near twice my size, fourteen years old

EDDIE: Hey, far be it! Far be it from me to give pointers - a guy got twenty six bouts under his belt, twelve professional

JOEY: Yeah, but this DeSapio, he really hates me, this kid; he hated me the minute he saw me. He says we killed Christ, us Jews.

EDDIE: They was all Jews there, kid, everybody; Christ, His mother, His whole crowd - you tell him there was a buncha Romans there too, makes him directly related to the guys done the actual hit!

JOEY: I told him that Pop - that's when he whacked me.

EDDIE: And I bet you whacked him back, which is appropriate; no shit from nobody, ya stuck to your guns, kid

JOEY: So why're we hidin' then? How come we're "Ross" all of a sudden? (With an edge.) Or maybe Ross is just our outdoor name, and Goldberg's still our indoor name.

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EDDIE: Hey

JOEY: I don't get it, this mean we're not Jewish anymore?

EDDIE: Of course we're still Jewish; we're just not gonna push it.

JOEY: (Checking watch.) Jeez - three minutes to eight, Pop, takes five to get there, he's gonna think I'm chicken - (Starts toward door.)

EDDIE: One minute for two pointers; let 'em wait, he'll get anxious

JOEY: He's not anxious, Pop, I promise ya

EDDIE: Now, these pointers is based on my observations o' your natural talents; the bounce,the eye, the smarts

JOEY: (Protesting.) Pop

EDDIE: C'mon, I seen you take out Itchy Halloran with one shot in fronta the Texaco Station; who're we kiddin' here? Hey, I was O.K., but you got potential I never had.

JOEY: But Itchy Halloran's my height, DeSapio's twice my size

EDDIE: (Ignoring him.) O.K., first blow; your instinct is go for the belly, right?

JOEY: Instinct? His belly is as high as I can reach, Pop

EDDIE: Wrong: first blow, forget the belly. Pointer Number One - ya listenin'?

JOEY: Yeah.

EDDIE: (Demonstrating, precisely.) Considerin' the size, you gotta rock this boy early. . . gotta take the first one up from the ground, vertical, so your full body-weight's in the shot. Now, start of the fight, right away, immediate, you hunk down, move outa range; then he's gotta come to you - and you meet him with a right fist up off the ground; picture a spot in the middle of his chin and aim for it - (Demonstrates blow, Joey copies.) then comes the important part

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JOEY: What's that?

EDDIE: Jump back.

JOEY: Jump back?

EDDIE: Yeah, ya jump back so when he falls he don't hurt ya.

JOEY: When he falls? Murder, he's gonna murder me. Pop, Pop, this is an execution I'm goin' to here! I'm only goin' so I won't be ashamed!

EDDIE: There's only one thing you gotta watch out for

JOEY: Death, I gotta watch out for death

EDDIE: Not death. . . but there could be some damage. Could turn out to be more than one guy there, you're gettin' ganged up on, somethin' special- this happens, kid - O.K., we got a weapon here - (Takes framed photo of boxer from wall.) we got a weapon here, guaranteed. (Hands photo to Joey.) What's it say there?

JOEY: (Reading.) "Anybody gives you trouble, give me trouble. I love you. Love, Vince."

EDDIE: O.K.; June Four, Nineteen Twenty-one, I come into the ring against Vince DiGangi, they bill him "The Ghetto Gorilla," - a shrimp with a moustache, nothin', I figure an easy win. Five seconds into Round One comes a chamalia from this little Eye-tie - I'm out, I'm on the canvas, your Pop is furniture, Joey. I open one eye, there's DiGangi on his knees next to me, he's got me in his arms, he's huggin' me, he's kissin' my face, he loves me. I give him his first big win, his first knockout. I made him, he says, he's gonna love me forever. And he does. That's the nice thing about these Telanas, they love ya or they hate ya, but it's forever; so, remember - (Leans towards him.) things get outa hand, you got a group

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situation, somethin' you holler "DiGangi e mio fratello, chiamalo!" (Grips his

shoulder.) "DiGangi e mio fratello, chiamalo!" Say it.

JOEY: "DiGangi e mio fratello, chi. . . amalo!"

EDDIE: That's: "DiGangi's my brother, call him!" (Softly, awestruck, imitating their response.) Whoa. . . "DiGangi" 's the magic word down there, biggest hit since Columbus, lotta power with the mob. Perhaps you noticed, Big Vito don't come around here pushin' protection, whatever. This is the result of one word from Mr. Vincent DiGangi. (Pats Joey's hand.) Very heavy ticket there, kid, you don't want to use it unless the straits is completely dire. (Slaps bar.) O.K., ya got all that?

JOEY: (Starting towards front door without much spirit.) Yeah. (As he passes stroller; softly, sighing.) Well. . . here I go.

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